

RAJDHANI EXPRESS

The introduction of the Rajdhani Express towards the end of the 1960s ushered in an era of speed, comfort, and luxury for the Indian passenger. Named to reflect its journey that began or ended in Delhi, the capital or *rajdhani*, these trains were the pioneers in the introduction of WAP electric locomotives, air-conditioning equipment innovations, and emergency lighting. Additionally, they set the standards for comfort and accessories that are now the norm in passenger coaches.

Making its maiden run between Howrah and New Delhi on 3 March 1969, the first Rajdhani Express covered the 1,145 km inter-city distance in 17 hours and 20 minutes. A single WDM-4 hauled this biweekly, eight-car train at a maximum permissible speed of 120 km/h. Initially, there were several objections to the train overshooting the speed mark as express trains mostly ran at speeds of 100 km/h. The Railway Board and the zones were opposed to the maximum speed limit, raising safety concerns and doubts about the tracks and the locomotives being able to support the high speeds.

However, this did not affect its popularity and a second 18-coach Rajdhani Express started operations between New Delhi and Bombay on 17 May 1972 and a third, which was added several decades later in 1992. In 1971, Kanpur was introduced as the first passenger stop and more halts were added to the route subsequently. The early Rajdhanis had first-class and AC chair car options, and other travel options, such as sleeper accommodation and two and three tier coaches, were added later. It also serves meals, the cost of which is included in the ticket price.

Created when airplane tickets were exorbitant and out of reach for the middle-class Indian, the Rajdhani proved to be the ultimate means of fast, comfortable, and affordable railway travel, especially since it was one of the first fully air-conditioned trains of the time.

Today, it is no longer viewed as the novel experience it used to be, yet, the Rajdhani's reservation-only accommodation, restricted number of